Kumar Nepal, who had been deputy prime minister in Nepal's first, 1994–5 communist government.

By then, the CPN-M had merged with another Maoist faction, the Communist Party of Nepal (Unity Centre) and become the Unified CPN-Maoist (UCPN-M). Eager to maintain good relations with their Nepalese comrades, the communist party leaders in Beijing invited Prachanda and other Maoist leaders to visit China in October 2009. Prachanda himself said before he and his delegation took off for Beijing, 'This will be one of the highest level meetings that has ever taken place between the two communist parties of Nepal and China. This visit will not only enhance ties between the two parties but will also contribute to strengthen Nepal's and China's age-old relationship.'[38]

Nepal's ambassador to China from 1998 to 2002, Rajeshwar Acharya said in an interview after the visit,

> It is indeed already assuming palpable significance. After the monarchy, the Chinese appear to be looking for a dependable ally in Nepal, and the Maoists seem to be willing to take on this role. Chinese policy needs to be analysed also in the context of Beijing's transparent desire to expand its contacts and linkages across the South Asian region.[39]

A Maoist became Nepal's PM again in August 2011, when Baburam Bhattarai took over the post. If there was any doubt that the Nepalese Maoists had abandoned their revolutionary ideals, his new economic policies settled it. Playing on anti-Indian sentiment in Nepal, Bhattarai wrote in a booklet published in 1998 that Nepal was 'India-locked' and went on to state that 'the biggest direct manifestation of world imperialist oppression and exploitation in Nepal is Indian expansionist exploitation and oppression'.[40] The way forward, he stated, 'would be to confiscate the means of production that have been in the hands of the reactionary classes … and then hand them over to the progressive forces'.[41]

No such thing happened during his premiership. Now Bhattarai wanted to strengthen the economy and improve the living standards of the people and, like Prachanda, he emphasized the importance of having good relations with both neighbours, China and India. Prachanda's first foreign visit as prime minister was to India in September 2008, and Bhattarai said on his visit to New Delhi as Nepal's PM in December 2011,

> We sincerely appreciate the Government and people of India for the continued cooperation in our development endeavors as a major development partner of Nepal…. we, in Nepal, have